

JAHANGIRNAGAR UNIVERSITY

DEPARTMENT OF ENGLISH

BA (HONOURS) 4TH YEAR FINAL EXAMINATION QUESTION BANK

COURSE CODE: E 411

COURSE TITLE: Morphology and Syntax

Target Stream: Concentration on Applied
Linguistics & ELT

Batches Included: 42, 43, 44, 46, 47, 48, 49, 50 (Batch 45 missing)

CURRENT SYLLABUS REFERENCE & SCOPE (Session: 2021–2022, Batch 51)

MORPHOLOGY:

- **Core Concepts:** Definition, classification, functions; Words vs. Lexemes; Wordhood tests; Types of words.
- **Word Formation Processes:** Affixation (prefixes, suffixes, infixes); Bases & roots; Derivation vs. Conversion; Compounding; Backformation; Blending; Clipping; Eponyms; Productivity; Mental lexicon.
- **Morphological Analysis:** Morphological rules and trees; Syntagmatic & paradigmatic relations; Morpheme, morph, and allomorph; Zero morph; Prosodic morphology.
- **Linguistic Interfaces:** Morphophonology, Morphosyntax, and Morphosemantics.

SYNTAX:

- **Syntactic Categories & Word Classes:** Verbs, nouns, adjectives, adverbs, prepositions; Lexical vs. Functional categories; Syntactic properties.
- **Constituent Structure:** Noun Phrase (NP head, pre-modifiers, post-modifiers); Verb Phrase (VP, operators, catenatives, tensed vs. non-tensed); Adjective Phrase (AdjP); Adverb Phrase (AdvP: adjuncts, subjuncts, disjuncts, conjuncts); Prepositional Phrase (PP).
- **Structural Analysis:** Immediate Constituent (IC) analysis; Syntactic constituency tests (movement, replacement, coordination, clefting).
- **Rules & Operations:** Phrase Structure (PS) rules; Tree diagrams; Transformational rules; Merger, projection, and adjunction; X-bar theory; Passivization; Ellipsis.
- **Clause Structure:** Clause components; Subordination vs. Coordination; Tense, aspect, voice, and mood.
- **Theories of Syntax:** Universal Grammar (UG); Government-Binding (GB) theory & Explanatory Adequacy; Lexical-Functional Grammar (LFG); Relational Grammar; Role and Reference Grammar (RRG).

SECTION A: BROAD QUESTIONS — MORPHOLOGY

Essay questions examining word structure, morphemic units, word-formation rules, and morphological productivity.

Morphology Essay Questions

1. "The term 'morpheme' is exploited to refer to the smallest meaningful observable syntactic or grammatical unit in a language that cannot be divided without altering or destroying its meaning." — Explicate and illustrate this proposition. [50]
2. Explain and exemplify the concepts of alternants, zero allomorphs, and substitution alternants as modifications of 'morpheme' propounded by Bloomfield. [50]
3. Differentiate between derivation and conversion. How do they contribute to forming new words of the same or different grammatical forms? [50]
4. Define allomorph. Write a brief note on the problems in morphological description in English. [49]
5. Write a contrastive essay on the derivational construction of words between English and Bengali with a special focus on semantic opportunities. [49, 48]
6. What are the features of morphological productivity? Discuss the possible entries of the mental lexicon in English. [49]
7. Exemplify the classification of English morphemes (free vs. bound, lexical vs. functional, derivational vs. inflectional). Discuss how morphemes in the English language can create analytical problems. [48]
8. Do you believe that "words" are the fundamental unit of linguistic structure? Discuss arguments in favour and against this proposition. [48]
9. Define Morphology. Explain and exemplify different types of morphemes with clear English examples. [47]

10. What are the processes of word formation in English? Explain and exemplify derivation, compounding, blending, clipping, and conversion. [47, 46]
11. Make a comprehensive list of the main prefixes and suffixes used in English today and categorize them according to their functions. [46]

SECTION B: BROAD QUESTIONS — SYNTAX

Essay questions exploring sentence constituent structure, phrase categories, syntactic operations, and grammatical theories.

Syntax Essay Questions

1. Why is the 'head' of an NP considered to be a compulsory constituent? Discuss the structures and functions of the different types of postmodifiers in a complex NP. [50]
2. Distinguish tensed verb phrases from non-tensed verb phrases. Discuss the diverse syntactic structures and functions of non-tensed verb phrases. [50, 48]
3. What factors help identify operators in verb phrases? Illustrate the diverse grammatical functions that operators perform (negation, inversion, emphasis, ellipsis). [50]
4. Expound adjuncts, subjuncts, disjuncts, and conjuncts. How do adverbs and adverb phrases syntactically and semantically function in sentences? [50]
5. Can determiners sometimes act as modifiers? Differentiate between free and bound grammatical morphemes. [50]
6. What is passivization? Discuss the syntactic and semantic functions of passivized constructions used in English. [49]
7. What are the basic tenets of Universal Grammar (UG) theory? How are thoughts transformed into linguistic expressions with reference to deep structure and surface structure? [49]
8. Define 'explanatory adequacy' in grammatical theories. Explain how the Government and Binding (GB) theory achieves explanatory adequacy, particularly with reference to English phrase structure rules and X-bar theory. [49]
9. Demonstrate the structure of a complex noun phrase. Exemplify different types of pre-modifiers and post-modifiers in English. [49, 48, 46]
10. What do you understand by subordination? Explicate different categories of subordinate clauses occurring in English syntactic constructions. [49]
11. What is modality? Explicate the functions of modal auxiliaries in English. Write down the characteristics of prepositional phrases. [48]
12. Discuss and exemplify different types of determiners in English expression. Explain how catenatives are constructed and their functions. [48]
13. Discuss the syntactic and semantic functions of adjectives and adverbs in English. [48, 46]
14. Differentiate between subordination and coordination in sentence architecture. [48]
15. Define ellipsis. What are the different kinds of ellipsis in English? Discuss their functions. [48]
16. Discuss how the modern study of syntax is scientific. [47]
17. Define "syntactic properties". Discuss various kinds of syntactic properties of words and phrases. [47]
18. What is "syntactic constituency"? Discuss various constituency tests with clear examples. [47]
19. What is "syntactic category"? Explain and exemplify lexical vs. phrasal categories. [47]
20. What are the essential features of Spoken English? How is it syntactically different from Written Discourse? [46]
21. Explain the following syntactic terms in detail: Modifiers, Determiners, and Complements. [46]
22. Explain the two different types of prepositional meanings and list the most common types of prepositions. [46]
23. Compare and contrast the sentence and the clause. Discuss the main structural types of clauses. [46]

24. What is the relationship between aspect and meaning? Discuss the progressive aspect in detail. [46]

SECTION C: SHORT NOTES & CONCISE CONCEPTS

Short notes on specialized morphological and syntactic concepts.

Short Notes Collection

1. Central and peripheral adjectives [50]
2. Central determiners vs. Pre-determiners and Post-determiners [50]
3. Time, tense, and aspect distinctions [50, 48]
4. Verb Phrase and Noun Phrase Ellipsis [50]
5. Prosodic morphology [49]
6. Core grammar vs. Peripheral grammar [49]
7. Mental lexicon and lexical access [49]
8. Compounds and compounding rules [49]
9. Allomorphs (Phonologically conditioned vs. Lexically conditioned) [48]
10. Eponyms [48]
11. Operators in the English verb phrase [48]
12. Grammaticality and ungrammaticality [47]
13. Recursion in natural language syntax [47]

SECTION D: PRACTICAL SYNTACTIC ANALYSIS & TREE DIAGRAMS

Hands-on structural parsing exercises, syntactic constituency tests, and Phrase Structure tree derivations.

Syntactic Constituency Testing [47]

Task: Decide if the italicized strings are 'syntactic constituents'. Validate your claim through appropriate constituency tests (e.g., Movement, Stand-Alone / Fragment, Pro-form Substitution, Coordination). Perform more than one test when possible:

1. I put *the letter* in the envelope.
2. I put the letter *in the envelope*.
3. I *put the letter* in the envelope.
4. *The angry men* and women walked in.
5. *The angry men and women* walked in.

Phrase Structure (PS) Tree Diagram Construction [47]

Task: Draw complete, labeled phrase structure trees (generating $S \rightarrow NP VP$) for each of the following sentences:

1. *He slowly walked down the street.*
2. *The tree in the backyard still has some leaves.*
3. *Both candidates are reportedly campaigning in Dhaka.*
4. *The child put the toy in the box.*
5. *The old tree swayed in the wind.*